

Age of scholarship

Hsien Ti, the last of the Han emperors, who reigned c.189–220 CE, is shown in discussion with scholars who have been busy translating Confucian classical texts.

In 124 BCE he established an imperial academy where 50 students studied the classics in preparation for an examination. Those who passed became eligible for official appointments. The same year saw the most celebrated example of social mobility in Chinese history when Gongsun Hong, a former swineherd, was appointed chancellor.

Expansion of the empire

During Wudi's long reign (141–87 BCE) China made extensive territorial gains.

**“To learn without thinking is fruitless;
To think without learning is dangerous.”**

CONFUCIUS, 551–479 BCE

The emperor's first concern, however, was to secure his northern frontier against invasion by the Xiongnu, a confederacy of nomadic steppe peoples originating in Mongolia (see p.139). In 166 BCE they had penetrated to within 100 miles (160 km) of Chang'an. In 138 BCE Wudi sent an envoy, Zhang Qian, to contact the Yuezhi, the traditional enemies of the Xiongnu, in the hope of forming an alliance. Zhang Qian failed to obtain their assistance, but his epic journey extended Chinese influence for the first time into the Western Regions (modern Xinjiang), helping establish trading links with Persia and opening up the Silk Road (see pp.184–85).

Wudi's greatest conquests were to the northeast and the south of the existing empire. In 128 BCE he sent an expedition to Korea, and 20 years later a longer campaign led to the establishment of four commanderies in the north of the peninsula. In 111 BCE he sent an expedition south to Guangzhou, and subsequently commanderies were established to administer the territory

of the modern provinces of Guangdong and Guangxi and north Vietnam. All these military campaigns naturally cost money, so Wudi decided to augment tax revenues by imposing a state monopoly on salt and iron. This provoked a complicated debate over the degree to which the government should interfere in the economy.

Decline and usurpation

Wudi's successful reign came to a sad end, as the emperor in his later years became obsessed with his search for immortality, enlisting the help of the leading alchemists of the day. After his death the dynasty went into a period of decline, marked by weak emperors

and the excessive influence of the court eunuchs. One of the eunuchs' main duties was the care of the numerous imperial concubines, any one of whose sons could be named to succeed the emperor. This led to palace intrigues in which the eunuchs played an increasingly significant role. The economy, meanwhile, suffered from financial mismanagement, and there was widespread tax evasion. A further blow came in the early years of the 1st century CE with serious flooding of the Yellow River, which led to its changing to its southern course in 11 CE.

In 9 CE Wang Mang, who had been acting as regent for a succession of child emperors, usurped the throne. He ordered large private estates to be broken up, but was killed in 23 CE.

The Han ruled China for over 400 years (ignoring the brief interregnum of Wang Mang)—longer than any later dynasty. Their administrative structure was revived and retained by future Chinese rulers.

THE ROMAN AND HAN EMPIRES

The two great contemporary empires of Eurasia—the **Roman Empire** << 106–115 in Europe and the Han in China—both collapsed, but whereas the Roman Empire disappeared, the Chinese Empire was reunited at the end of the 6th century CE and survived for another 1,400 years. Important factors in the durability of the Chinese Empire compared to the Roman Empire may have been the fact that China was a land empire and was held together by a common written



ROMAN COIN OF EMPEROR TRAJAN

language, the principles of Confucianism 130–31 >>, and the ideal of ethical rule by an emperor. The Romans governed a sprawling empire populated by people speaking many languages.

AGE OF DIVISION

The fall of the Later Han was followed by a period of division between north and south. The north, at first fragmented into the **Sixteen Kingdoms**, was then dominated by the **Northern Wei dynasty**, while to the south a succession of **Six Dynasties** established their capital at Jiankang (modern Nanjing). In 589 CE China was reunited under the Sui dynasty and then in 618 CE by the **Tang dynasty 160–61 >>**, which ushered in a new period of stability. Under the Tang, long-distance trade between China and the Middle East revived along the **Silk Road 184–85 >>**, especially with the newly established **Islamic Caliphate 174–77 >>**.

The Later Han

In 25 CE Guang Wudi reestablished the Han dynasty, transferring the capital to Luoyang, which became the most populous city in the world. This was an age of scientific and technological progress; major inventions included paper (see below) and an instrument that indicated the direction in which an earthquake had occurred. In its

later years the Han court was weakened by factionalism, and China was menaced by the Xianbei, a new confederation of steppe nomads. Rebellions broke out, and Han generals, the most famous of whom was Cao Cao, contended for power. In 220 Cao Cao died and the dynasty collapsed.

**INVENTION****PAPER**

The invention of paper is traditionally credited to Cai Lun, a court eunuch who lived c. 50–121 CE. He soaked the bark of a mulberry tree and bamboo in water, pounded the mixture with a wooden tool, and then drained it through cloth, leaving only the fibers. This produced a type of paper that was light, cheap, and easy to make. His invention was adopted rapidly for documents and books and subsequently spread to the Islamic world and the West.

**Han dynasty China**

Under Wudi, the Han extended their control over south China. The Great Wall of China was originally constructed during the Han Dynasty and rebuilt in later periods.